

Evan Mobley (Order #29860615)

THE WORLD NEEDS HEROES

Prowlers & Paragons Ultimate Edition **includes everything you need to create unique superheroes and play exciting stories right out of comic books and movies. Within these pages you'll find countless powers and power options, extensive rules for gear, vehicles, and even headquarters, a massive assortment of animals and non-player characters, and extensive guidance to help gamemasters run the most engaging superhero games possible. Last but not least, this book includes 38 ready-to-play characters, heroes and villains.**

Prowlers & Paragons Ultimate Edition **was designed to be highly flexible, allowing you to play anything from street-level vigilantes to high-flying paragons with godlike abilities, from gritty hard-boiled detective stories to four-color cartoon adventures. This edition expands the original to allow for many more options while also streamlining the rules and making the game even faster and easier to run.** ***Prowlers & Paragons Ultimate Edition*** **is the only roleplaying game you need to run any kind of superhero adventure you can imagine.**

In 2013, when the world needed heroes, you answered the call. You and your allies were all that stood between light and darkness, good and evil, right and wrong. You fought valiantly and sacrificed dearly. And you saved the day. But ignorance, greed, and tyranny never sleep. Once again, the world is in peril, Hero. Once again, the world needs you to...

TAKE A STAND! JOIN THE FIGHT! BE A HERO!

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EVIL BEAGLE GAMES

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FORWARD

HANDFULS OF DICE

That was the superhero game I was going to design, develop, and publish. Len Pimentel killed that idea with a 20d Penetrating Blast right through the chest. I'm oddly okay with that.

Let me explain...

January 2014 – Sean furiously scratches out all kinds of notes, talks to friends, makes more notes, plays with outlines and structures... comes up with the following "manifesto" for his Design Goals:

- *Strong Thematic Builds encouraged*
- *Flexibility with Powers*
- *Fun to play, fun to run*
- *Fun to create characters*
- *Quick build for last-minute characters*

Ultimately, I am trying to combine newer design ideas (with an emphasis on narrative influence and fast-and-easy gaming) with some very retro stuff (huge handfuls of dice, crunchy hit-then-damage resolutions). I want to create the game that my friends wish to play, and that I will truly enjoy running. Hopefully that will translate to something lots of other folks enjoy as well.

May 2015 – Sean's playtesting this bad boy, getting all kinds of feedback. He adds in more and more stuff to fill everything out. Campaign Scale Chart. Categories for the different levels of abilities, the different ways characters are designed, so much **stuff**! Then the word is given — S*avage Rifts®* is a reality, and Sean's life will brook no other game design on anything else.

But... Sean wants to play supers!

So, yeah, I had to shelve HoD*, but I couldn't dump my desire to run a supers campaign in my* Modern Gods *setting. I needed a good system for it, something that at least got close to my specific ideas, so I went looking.*

Again.

I'd already tried running Modern Gods *(and my other supers world, Unending War) in just about every single superhero RPG rules set there is. Ask my Belovedest, Carinn (Evil Beagle's Editor-in-Chief); the poor woman endured countless iterations, reboots, and reconfigurations, and more than a few attempts to hack existing rules. Nothing ever quite got where I wanted to go.*

You have to understand what I was looking for — a superhero RPG rules system that somehow evoked all the great things I remembered fondly about Champions (specifically the 4th Edition era, which is when I wrote extensively for it) while also fulfilling the promise of easier-access, fast-play gaming that is the hallmark of current game design. Having a bit more narrative impetus as part of the experience was another element of 21st Century RPG thinking I wanted to incorporate.

That's where the work on Handfuls of Dice *started, and when I had to put it aside, I went looking one more time to see if there was any game that might get close to what I'd hoped for. I took a look at a couple of Top Five, Top Ten, and Best Of lists online that talked about superhero games. Then, I started looking at quite a few more, noticing a game I'd not really paid any attention to before showing up time-and-time again.*

Prowlers & Paragons.

I grabbed it, read it, and realized with abject shame that I had seen it before, and had summarily dismissed it as "one of those frou-frou narrative games that didn't try to be a real game."

Let me explain! When I first encountered it, I was in a crotchety, grognard kind of headspace about light, narrative games. I got over it — and myself — but my first encounter with the game was in light of that preconception, so I didn't really give it the attention it deserved.

Worse, it was something a dear friend had shown me, a guy named Leonard Pimentel, who I met at Gen Con a few years ago and, in the moment of that meeting, discovered one of those human beings that you just know you are going to be best friends forever with.

(As always, he and I have Carinn to thank for that; he played in a game she ran, and she somehow knew she had to introduce us. Thank you, Love!)

But... I just didn't grasp it then, put it aside, and continued my search, which eventually led me to Handfuls of Dice*, and then* Savage Rifts® *had to be done, so I had to find a system to fill in and... you've read this part already, right?*

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Right.

So here I am, re-encountering this game that's getting all kinds of new love, and I am really reading it this time. Ten minutes later, I am dialing Len's mobile. His voicemail picks up, and I practically scream into it "Pimentel, you magnificent bastard, I read your book!"

(If you didn't hear that in George C. Scott's voice, you've missed out on one of the greatest character studies disguised as a war movie of all time. Fix that.)

A few minutes later, he calls me back. We laugh, we cry, we completely redevelop the entire thing, and now you have what I predict will go down in RPG history as one of the greatest superhero RPG systems of all time.

What happened to HoD*? Will I ever finish it?*

No need. Took my best ideas, married them to this extraordinary engine, and made something so very much better.

Len Pimentel is one of the most talented game designers in this industry that you probably don't know about. I believe this is the game that changes that. I am honored and thrilled to have had a part in making this better, but it was already pretty damn good, because he's just that clever and that talented. I might have added a few good things here and there; if so, you're the beneficiary of that combined effort. We started from an amazing foundation of Len's crafting.

Go forth, tell amazing superhero stories, and know that I am genuinely looking forward to you telling me about your character at the next convention we see each other.

Now where's my giant bag of d6s?

Sean Patrick Fannon



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INTRODUCTION

I want to be a superhero. You want to be a superhero. Everyone wants to be a superhero. Or at least everyone would like to have superpowers. Ever since we learned to tell stories, we've told stories of people who could do things we could only dream of: stories that empowered us, stories that motivated us, stories that entertained us. We told these stories for countless generations, repeating some so often that they evolved into myths and legends, becoming an integral part of our cultural fabric. These stories were important. We understand this, rationally and intuitively. We know that our myths and legends are an essential part of who we were, who we are, and who we may become. That's why we collect these stories, catalog them, and study them in the halls of academia. And yet, we often fail to acknowledge the myths and legends of the present: superheroes. Having grown out of the wild assortment of escapist genres collectively referred to as *pulp*, the superhero genre is the latest iteration of our never-ending fascination with the idea that we can be more than we are. It's a genre with a long and venerable history, one more important than we often care to admit.

For a long time, all we did was tell stories. Then we started acting them out, first around fires, then on stage, in sound studios, and eventually on screen. But actually pretending to live those stories out for the sheer joy of it, or for the emotional catharsis of it? That kind of make-believe was deemed frivolous, an activity reserved for children. Or at least that was the case until not too long ago, when a pair of mad geniuses in the magical land of Wisconsin collaborated on a game that allowed players to actually step into the roles of heroic adventurers. That game deservedly went on to become the world's most popular roleplaying game, and the idea of letting players participate as heroes in the telling of these epic stories took the world by storm, laying the groundwork for whole industries that had yet to be developed. This game was written while balancing on the shoulders of those Wisconsin giants and the pioneers who applied their ideas to the superhero genre. Without them, we wouldn't be here.

If you're reading this, you probably have an interest in superheroes and roleplaying games. Good for you. You have a long line of humans behind you, stretching all the way back to those scattered groups of preliterate beings whose amazing brains gave them the capacity to wonder, to imagine, and to tell stories of what might be. Our ancestors sitting around their campfires would have loved the idea of participating in the stories they told rather than just telling them, but that would be a while in coming. It's here now, though, thanks in part to them. That long line of humans is standing over your shoulder, marveling at the stories you and your friends create every time you play, so make them proud.

Thank you for your interest in *Prowlers & Paragons Ultimate Edition*. It warms our hearts and humbles us more than we can express. Now go create some myths of your own.

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WELCOME BACK!

Or for those who are joining us for the first time, welcome aboard! *Prowlers & Paragons Ultimate Edition* (or **P&P**), is the revised, expanded, and much-improved edition of the original *Prowlers & Paragons*. P&P is a tabletop roleplaying game with a rules-light engine that blends narrative task resolution and concrete combat rules to create a unique system designed to emulate four-color superhero comics.

Great, so what does that mean to you?

P&P is a tabletop roleplaying game. If that one threw you for a loop, you're in for a treat. Skip to the next section, *What is Roleplaying*, to see what you've gotten yourself into.

P&P is rules-light. As far as roleplaying games go, P&P is a simple game with streamlined rules. Once you know how things work, you should be able to play without ever opening the book. Although simple rules might not work for every genre, this is a game about superheroes, and light rules are less troublesome when mimicking comic-book action rather than real-world physics.

P&P blends narrative task resolution and concrete combat rules. For the most part, P&P relies on what's become a signature element in many narrative game systems; rather than telling you what happens, the rules help you figure out who gets to describe what happens. However, P&P isn't a purely narrative game, especially not when it comes to combat. The combat rules are more defined, adding a tactical element to ensure that players feel like superheroes rather than comic book writers.

Last, P&P is designed to emulate four-color superhero comics. This game tries to capture the reality of the superhero genre rather than simulate the real world and its pesky physical laws. P&P is a game about superheroes, about the heroic things they do, and the heroic burdens they shoulder. Mundane matters get little to no attention. While the game includes elements designed to encourage good roleplaying, the focus isn't on the emotionality or psychology of being a superhero. To be perfectly clear, P&P isn't a deep and cerebral game. It's a game designed to let you play stories about superheroes who save the world and beat the snot out of supervillains who richly deserve it. Like so much of the genre, P&P is a gleefully unapologetic exercise in escapism and heroic wish fulfillment.

WHAT IS ROLEPLAYING

If you're reading this, you probably already know the answer to that question. Nowadays, many people have played or watched someone else play a tabletop roleplaying game, whether live or online. And many more have been introduced to the basic idea of roleplaying games through video games and massively multiplayer online roleplaying games such as the sadly defunct and still sorely missed *City of Heroes* (*we promised ourselves we wouldn't cry*).

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A tabletop roleplaying game is one in which a group of people collectively create a story. When you play P&P, you take on the role of a superhero (a **Hero**) in the imaginary world in which the game takes place. You and your fellow players create your own Heroes and control them in the game. You're usually cooperating with rather than competing against your fellow players because there's no winning or losing. You play for the fun of it rather than to beat your opponents or win the game. Again, this should be familiar to anyone who's ever played a massively multiplayer online roleplaying game.

While most of the people playing *P&P* — or any tabletop roleplaying game — play a specific Hero, one person takes on the role of the gamemaster (or **GM**). The GM has three responsibilities. First, the GM comes up with the stories in which the Heroes become involved and creates the supervillains and other characters with whom the Heroes interact. Second, the GM acts as the narrator of the story and plays these non-player characters (or **NPCs**) during the game. Third, the GM acts as the moderator of the game and decides when and how to apply the rules.

P&P takes place in the minds of the people playing the game. There are no pieces to move around a board, no cards to shuffle and hand out, nothing like that. Instead, when the game begins, the GM sets the stage by telling the players where their Heroes are and what's happening around them. The players imagine themselves in that situation and tell the GM what they do in return. The GM describes what happens in response, the players react to that, and so on. There are times when you have to roll dice and consult the rules, but most of the time, the game involves nothing more than this back-and-forth conversation between the GM and the players as they make their way through the story.

Games usually last three to six hours, but some folks enjoy longer sessions. A game session normally ends when the story concludes, but many stories take more than a single session to finish. As a result, game sessions often end when GM feels the group has reached a logical stopping point.

GLOSSARY

In the spirit of the source material that inspired this game, we sometimes use comic-book lingo in place of common roleplaying terms. Other times, we stick with traditional roleplaying game terminology, or we use everyday words to mean something specific. Here's what we mean by the following terms.

Extra: A character run by the GM who isn't a Villain, Foe, or Minion. Extras can be mundane civilians of any stripe, good, evil, or anywhere in between. They can also be characters with powers who aren't enemies, such as other superheroes or neutral parties who just happen to have superpowers.

Foe: A henchman, lieutenant, or minor enemy who poses more of a threat than a Minion but isn't as competent or dangerous as a Villain. Like all enemy characters, Foes are run by the GM.

GM: An abbreviation for gamemaster, the person who runs the game.

Half: Whenever we refer to half of an odd number (or half of an odd number of dice), always round up, regardless of the context. For example, half of 3d is 2d and half of 1d is 1d.

Hero: A character — presumably a superhero — run by a player. A player may occasionally control other characters, but only their main character is considered a Hero.

Issue: A single session of gameplay. Just like every issue of a well-written comic, every issue of P&P should start with a bang and end with something that leaves the players hungry for more.

Minion: Minions are generic enemies like gang members, killer robots, ninjas, or toughs, characters who only pose a threat to the Heroes in groups. Like all enemy characters, Minions are run by the GM.

NPC: Short for non-player character, this is any character run by the GM.

Page: Often called a round or a turn in other roleplaying games, a page is a brief unit of in-game time that represents a few seconds of combat or any other fast-moving scene. It represents roughly one page of a comic book or a few moments of an action sequence in a movie or show.

Scene: A variable unit of in-game time roughly equivalent to one chapter of a book or one scene of a movie or show. Scenes normally revolve around a specific action, event, goal, location, or task.

Series: Often called a campaign in other roleplaying games, a series is a collection of stories that typically involve the same Heroes and unfold in chronological order. While this term usually refers to an ongoing campaign that can last months or even years, that doesn't have to be the case. As in the comics, you can instead have a one-shot series, which is really just a single story, or a mini-series that involves a limited number of stories connected by an overarching metaplot.

Story: Often called an adventure in other roleplaying games, a story is a single tale that involves the Heroes and has a distinct beginning, middle, and end. Unlike in a traditional story, however, the collaborative nature of roleplaying makes it entirely possible that the story that gets told over the course of the game turns out to be very different than what the GM originally had in mind.

Travel Power: A type of Power that lets you move faster than a normal person.

Villain: A competent, dangerous, or important enemy who is at least as powerful as the Heroes if not much more so. Like all enemy characters, Villains are run by the GM.

Xd: This indicates a number of ordinary 6-sided dice. For example, when you roll 8d, you roll 8 dice of the ordinary 6-sided variety. Modifiers of +Xd or -Xd require you to add or subtract that many dice before rolling them. For example, a –2d penalty means you roll 2 fewer dice than normal.

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